Bridging the Gap

A look at law school training and expectations for graduates to be practice ready.

Path to Practice
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Bloomberg Law

Law Students Graduate Light on Client, AI Skills

By Ava Mandoli

Law students are entering the workforce feeling shaky about the skills needed for success, as technology changes the profession.

Four in 10 students surveyed said their classes helped them gain proficiency in using generative AI-driven legal tools. Just a third said they feel confident in client management or client counseling, according to Bloomberg Law's 2026 Path to Practice survey.

The way law school is structured helps explain why some students don't feel practice-ready upon graduation. Surveyed 3Ls said they had taken more than twice as many foundational courses as skills-based ones.

Matthew Asbell, a partner at Lippes Mathias and an adjunct law professor at two New York City schools, said he believes students aren't well prepared for some aspects of a legal career, including how to build and maintain a professional network.

"Law schools need to do a better job of forcing or driving students into the larger social community of law practice," said Asbell, who teaches at Fordham Law School and the Cardozo School of Law. "A lot of them don't even know how to navigate bar associations."

While law schools focus on theoretical foundations, the demand for practice-ready graduates has intensified, and practicing attorneys have high expectations of recent law school graduates.

For example, 76% of practicing attorneys expect new hires to be proficient in checking citations from AI-generated material on Day One. Nearly two-thirds also expect recent law school graduates to be comfortable conducting work product review.

Kaidi Zhang, a Stanford Law 2L, said it's up to students to seek out skills-based courses that prepare them for work. At Stanford and UC Berkeley Law, where he spent his first year, Zhang found most courses gave students a foundation in understanding law.

"There's way more specific stuff that you need to learn before you can become a practitioner," Zhang said, adding courses focused on theory that he's taken aren't "designed for you to be like the top notch-practitioner in that field."

Students are making a substantial effort to supplement their theory-based classes by seeking paid employment opportunities. Nearly all 3Ls said they did some paid work during law school, such as an internship or clerkship, signaling that they're at least trying to bridge the gap between law school and the workplace.

More than half of the students said their school's career center helped them secure paid opportunities during school. About a third said school-sponsored networking events and on-campus interviews were also useful.

Still, there's room for law schools to improve. About a quarter of students who had paid employment during school said their schools didn't directly help them secure these opportunities.

While these opportunities are valuable resume-builders, the extent to which short-term work experiences adequately prepare students on how to use AI in the workplace remains unclear.

As AI transforms the industry, most attorneys said they feel the technology is growing faster than they keep up, and half believe the tech will reduce opportunities for graduating law students.

Unfortunately, there is no guarantee that students are gaining the competencies needed to use AI in all law schools. The way law schools are integrating AI into coursework depends on the school and the professor.

Only 11% of faculty said their law school requires professors to take AI training. Two-thirds of faculty said their institution offers optional training or workshops on integrating new technologies into their courses.

Even when AI training, workshops and courses are offered to help faculty incorporate new technologies into the curriculum, nearly a quarter said they haven't taken any of these trainings.

University of Denver law school professor Tim Holbrook said a one-size-fits-all approach to teaching students about AI may not always make sense. However, he also said that making such classes optional could result in some law students graduating without ever learning how to use AI legal tools in the workplace.

Holbrook may be right. Partners are less versed in AI, according to students and attorneys, who believe that more tenured lawyers are not as savvy with legal technology. Still, the expectation is that a practicing lawyer should know how to use the technology responsibly.

"Increasingly, the expectation will be that new law graduates have AI experience and facility. The irony is that a lot of the senior partners probably don't," Holbrook said.

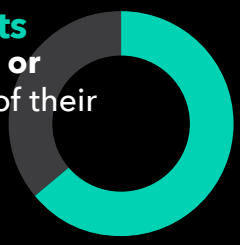
An Eye Toward AI

Look for this icon throughout this report to find data specifically related to artificial intelligence.

Data at a Glance

Law Student Courses

64% of 3L law students **have interacted with real or simulated clients** as part of their professional training.

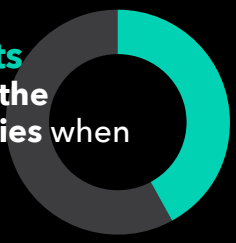


The average 3L has taken five skills-based courses (designed to teach and refine practical skills) but **more than twice as many core foundational courses**.

Law Student Opinions

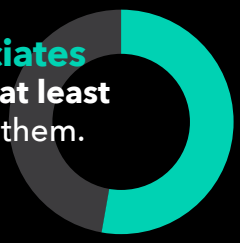
Only one-third of 1Ls feel they have **some proficiency in using generative AI as legal tech**, while 4 out of 10 3L students do.

42% of law students believe **AI will reduce the number of opportunities** when they graduate.

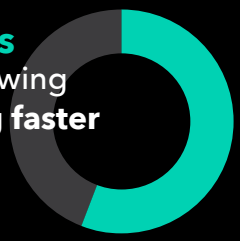


Attorney Experiences

53% of law firm associates say that making partner is **at least moderately important** to them.



56% of attorneys agree with the following statement: "**AI is growing faster than I can keep up**."



Faculty and Legal Tech

66% of law school faculty have **voluntarily taken courses, workshops or training to learn new legal technology**, though only 17% said such courses are required by their schools. And one in four have had no new legal tech training at all.*

Optional workshops or courses	66%
I have **not taken any**	24
Required workshops or courses	17

*Among faculty who said their school offers AI training

Student

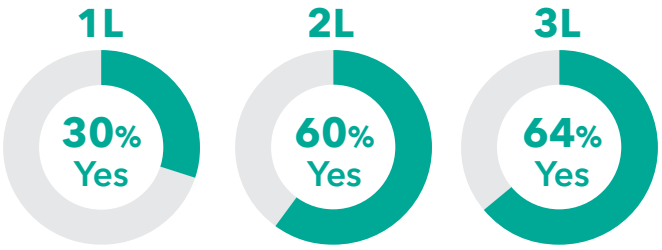
Law School Courses and Curriculum

Which of these skills do you feel you have **developed some proficiency** in as a result of your law school coursework?

Skills	1L	2L	3L
Legal research	**79%**	**95%**	**92%**
Legal writing	**86**	**91**	**85**
Legal tech: Databases	74	77	70
Time management	57	63	51
Professionalism and ethics	36	64	70
Legal tech: Generative AI	33	39	40
Oral advocacy	8	49	49
Client counseling / Interviewing	17	31	36
Legal tech: Dockets	11	26	28
Client / Case management	7	18	30
Contract drafting	3	19	30
None of these	3	1	4

Have you **interacted with any clients, including simulated clients**?

A "simulated client" is a person or AI program meant to help law students practice their professional skills.



By the time students have completed their second year of law school, most of them have engaged with either a real or simulated client at least once.

Legal research and writing courses are the bread and butter of law schools, with about nine in 10 students saying they feel proficient at both. At least 70% of students across all years feel proficient in using databases because of their coursework.

Overall, **students feel least confident when it comes to contract drafting, using dockets and client-facing skills** like case management and client counseling. The lack of client exposure for more than a third of 2L and 3L students underscores their lack of confidence in case management and client counseling.

Students still spend most of their time in foundational courses learning about the rules, principles, and theories of law, not in skills development. During their first two years, students take a median of three times more foundational classes than classes that focus on practical skills. In their 3L year, the focus shifts slightly more toward practical skills with 3Ls having taken a median of five skills-based courses and 12 core foundational courses.

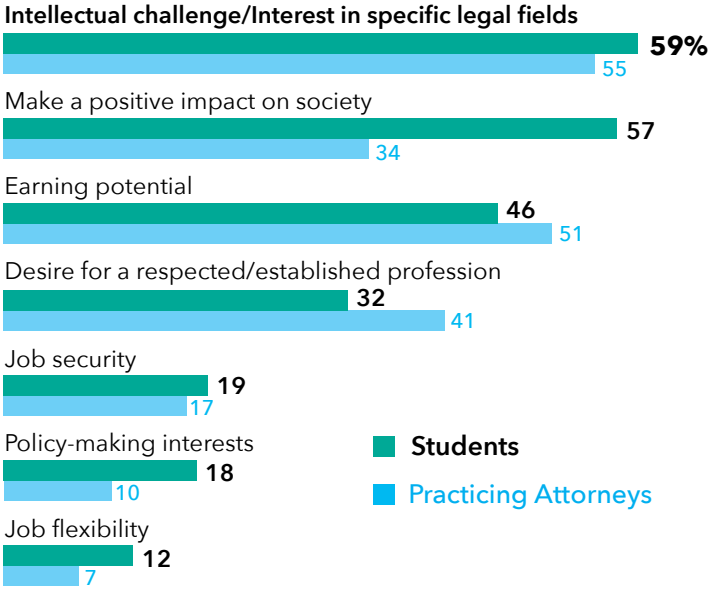
How many of each of the following types of courses have you taken during your time at law school, including this current semester?

	Median # of Classes Taken		
Courses	**1L**	**2L**	**3L**
Core foundational Traditional law school education focused on rules, principles, and theories	3	9	12
Skills-based Designed to teach and refine practical skills needed to practice law	1	3	5

Student

Academics and Employment

Why did you choose to pursue a law degree?*



Have you participated in any of the following **paid employment opportunities** (including employment over the summer) while in law school?

Select all that apply.

Employment	1L	2L	3L
No paid opportunities	**94%**	32	14
Had paid opportunities	6	**68%**	**86%**
• Internship	2	45	71
• Research assistant	1	26	35
• Externship	0	17	23
• Clerkship	0	12	14
• Other	4	6	12

Students and attorneys pursued law largely for the same reasons. **Both groups rank the intellectual challenge and earning potential highly.** Making a positive impact was more important to students (57%) compared to attorneys (34%). The prestige of being a lawyer meant more to attorneys when they went to law school (41%) than it does for students today (32%).

Getting a relevant, paid job while attending law school bridges coursework and the start of a legal career, but securing those opportunities takes time. **Only 6% of surveyed 1L students had obtained paid employment while in law school, compared to 86% of 3L students.**

Seven out of 10 3L students had paid internships—the most popular type of employment for them—and roughly a third had been research assistants. Students also participated in externships and clerkships, though less frequently.

Law schools are often instrumental in helping students get these employment opportunities. **More than half of all students reported using their school's career center services.** On campus interviews and school-related networking opportunities were also valuable, with around 30% of students saying they helped them get a job while in law school. However, around a quarter of students said their law school didn't help them find employment.

For those students who worked while in law school, did your school do anything to help you obtain your paid employment opportunities?

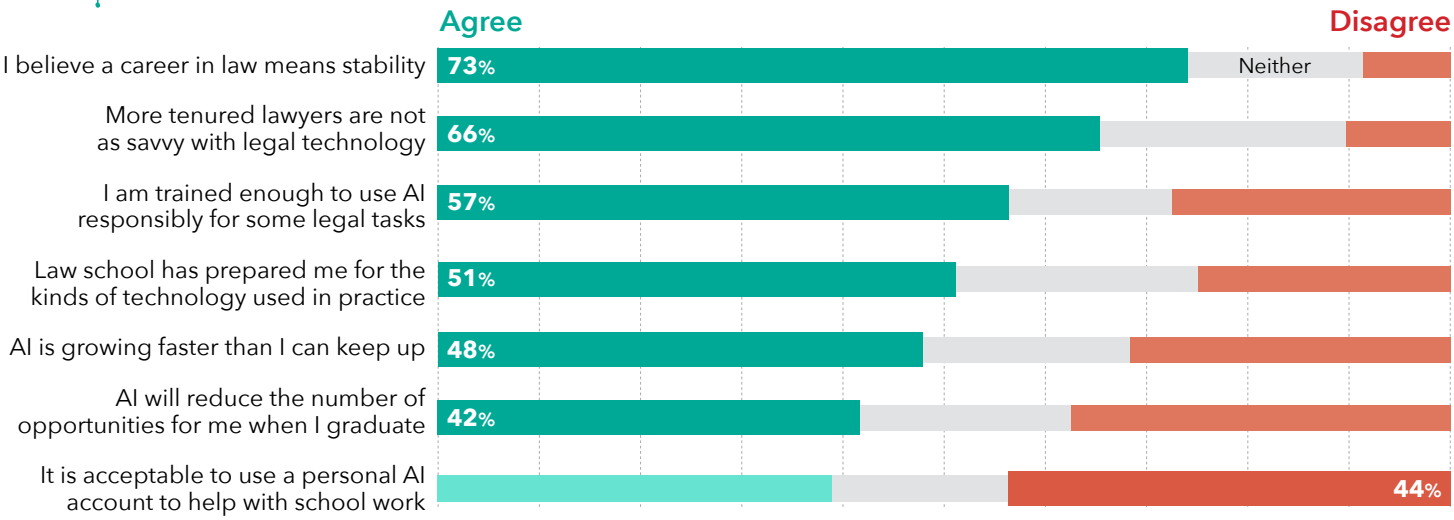
Career center services (job postings, counseling, etc.)	**54%**
Law school networking events or job fairs	32
On-campus interviews (OCIs)	32
Alumni/Personal connections	29
No, the law school did not help me directly	27
Faculty referrals/ recommendations	21
The law school sponsored/ paid me directly	17

*Only student answers above 10% are shown.

Student

Law Student Opinions and Aspirations

Do you **agree or disagree** with each of the following statements?



AI is transforming every industry and the technology is changing fast. **Nearly half the students said AI is growing faster than they can keep up and 42% believe the tech will reduce their job opportunities.** About 6 in 10 students feel they have enough training to use AI responsibly for some legal tasks.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, **two-thirds of students said more tenured lawyers aren't tech savvy.**

While some in the legal world believe AI will reduce entry-level hiring, students are still optimistic about their career prospects. To 73%, a career in law means stability.

The allure of Big Law is strong. **Nearly a quarter of students said an associate position at a large law firm was the job they hoped to secure after graduating.** Public interest positions ranked second with 18% of students selecting that as their top choice.

Many students aiming for associate positions don't feel strongly about becoming a partner one day. **Around half of students said making partner is slightly or moderately important to them** while 19% are set on this goal. Nearly three in 10 students said making partner isn't important or applicable to them.

Which of the following positions most align with your **career goals after you graduate**? *Select one.*

Associate at a large law firm (500+ attorneys)	**22%**
A public interest position	18
Associate at a mid-sized law firm (50-499)	17
Associate at a small law firm (fewer than 49)	10
In-house attorney on a corporate legal team	10
Clerkship	9
Government position	8
Other	6

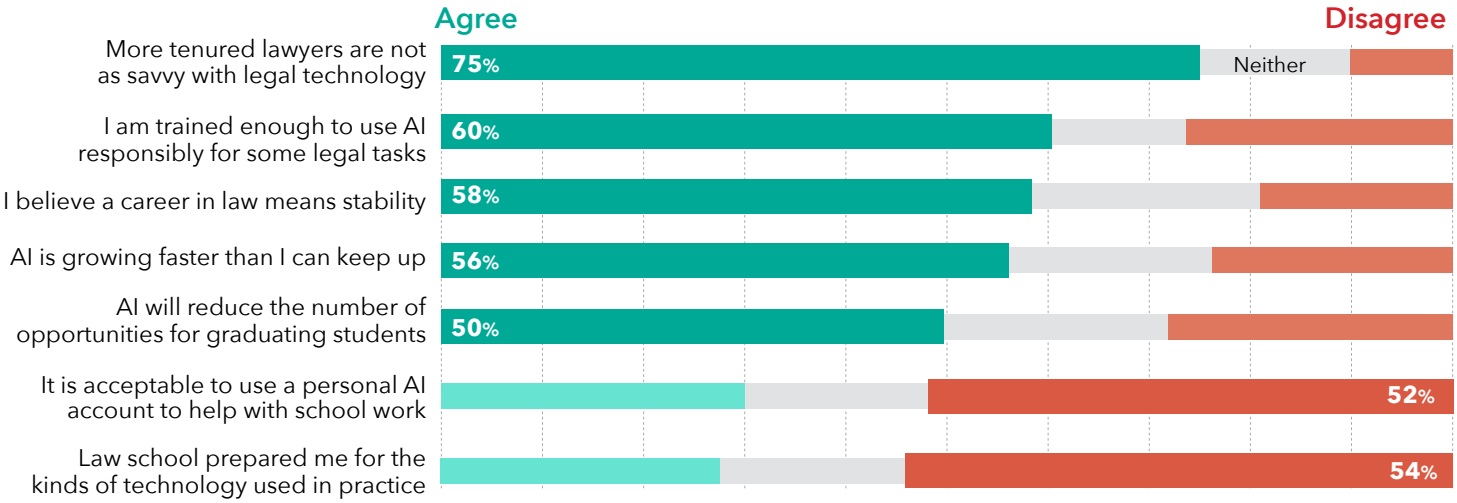
For those who want to be associates (at any size firm), **how important is it to you to make partner**?

28%	53%	19%
Not at all/ Not applicable	Slightly/ Moderately	Very/ Extremely

Practicing Attorney

Experience and Expectations

Do you **agree or disagree** with each of the following statements?



Practicing attorneys are even less confident about the tech skills of their colleagues than students are. **Three quarters of attorneys surveyed agree that more tenured lawyers aren't as savvy with legal tech.** Compared to law students, attorneys were also more pessimistic about AI's impact on the job market: Half said they believe the tech will reduce entry-level opportunities.

Generative AI has gone from novelty to mainstay in a little more than three years. Its growth helps explain why **54% of attorneys disagree that law school prepared them for the technology they need in practice.**

The bar will be set even higher for the next generation of lawyers, which must combat AI hallucination. **Verifying sources cited by AI, or cite checking, was the top AI-related skill that attorneys said new lawyers should have** when they start practicing. Nearly two-thirds also expect new associates to have work product review skills and a strong understanding of the legal ethics of AI.

Making partner was slightly more motivating to current law firm associates than students, with 25% calling it very important. About half said making partner is moderately important, roughly the same amount as students who are pursuing associate positions.

Which **AI skills should new attorneys already have** when starting a new role?*

Cite-checking	**76%**
Work product review	63
Understanding of the legal ethics of AI	63
AI literacy	46
AI-assisted writing	17
Prompt engineering	14
None of these; they are expected to learn on the job	11
AI simulation / Red-teaming	5

For associates at law firms (large or small), **how important is it to you to make partner**?

28%	47%	25%
Not at all/ Not applicable	Slightly/ Moderately	Very/ Extremely

*Asked specifically of respondents who hire or manage junior associates or entry-level attorneys

Faculty

Training, AI and Legal Technology

To your knowledge, what does your law school offer to **train faculty to integrate new technologies** into their courses? If training is offered, **have you participated**?* *Select all that apply.*

Faculty Training	Law school offers...	Faculty participation
Optional training or workshops	**66%**	66%
No training	20	N/A
Required training or workshops	11	17
Other	11	8
Faculty receive a stipend for training in areas like new tech	4	4

*24% didn't take training that was offered.

What is the policy of your law school on **students' use of AI assistance** for courses or assessments? *Select one.*

Course-level policies vary	33%
We have a school-wide policy communicated to students	30
No formal policy has been adopted	13
Use of Gen AI is generally not allowed (except as part of a course on the subject)	11
Something else	7
We have general guidelines and reminders, but do not enforce rules	6

A key question stands out: **Are law school faculty prepared to teach AI-to-practice at their own institutions?**

Two-thirds said their school provides optional training to help faculty integrate new tech in their courses, while 11% said it's mandatory. Another 20% said this training isn't offered.

Just three in 10 faculty said their law schools have a school-wide AI policy. A third had policies that varied depending on the course, and 13% said there's no formal policy.

The types of courses offered about AI vary. Slightly more than four in 10 faculty said their law school offers courses that focus on the basics of AI and its uses in legal practice. A third said there are courses on generative or agentic AI in practice, and about a third said there are classes in AI and legal ethics. **Almost three in 10 faculty, however, said their school doesn't offer any AI-focused courses.**

At the school where you teach, what types of **courses focused on AI in the legal industry** does your school offer? *Select all that apply.*

Introductory courses (e.g. the basics of AI tech and its use cases in legal practice)	43%
Advanced/specialized courses on generative or agentic AI in practice	33
Courses dedicated to AI and legal ethics	32
Our school does not offer any courses where AI is the primary focus	28
Interdisciplinary courses (e.g., law + computer science or ethics)	26
Tech-focused legal clinics (e.g., how to use AI to increase access to justice)	12
Other	7

Prestige Metrics

Peer Perceptions: Alternative Schools

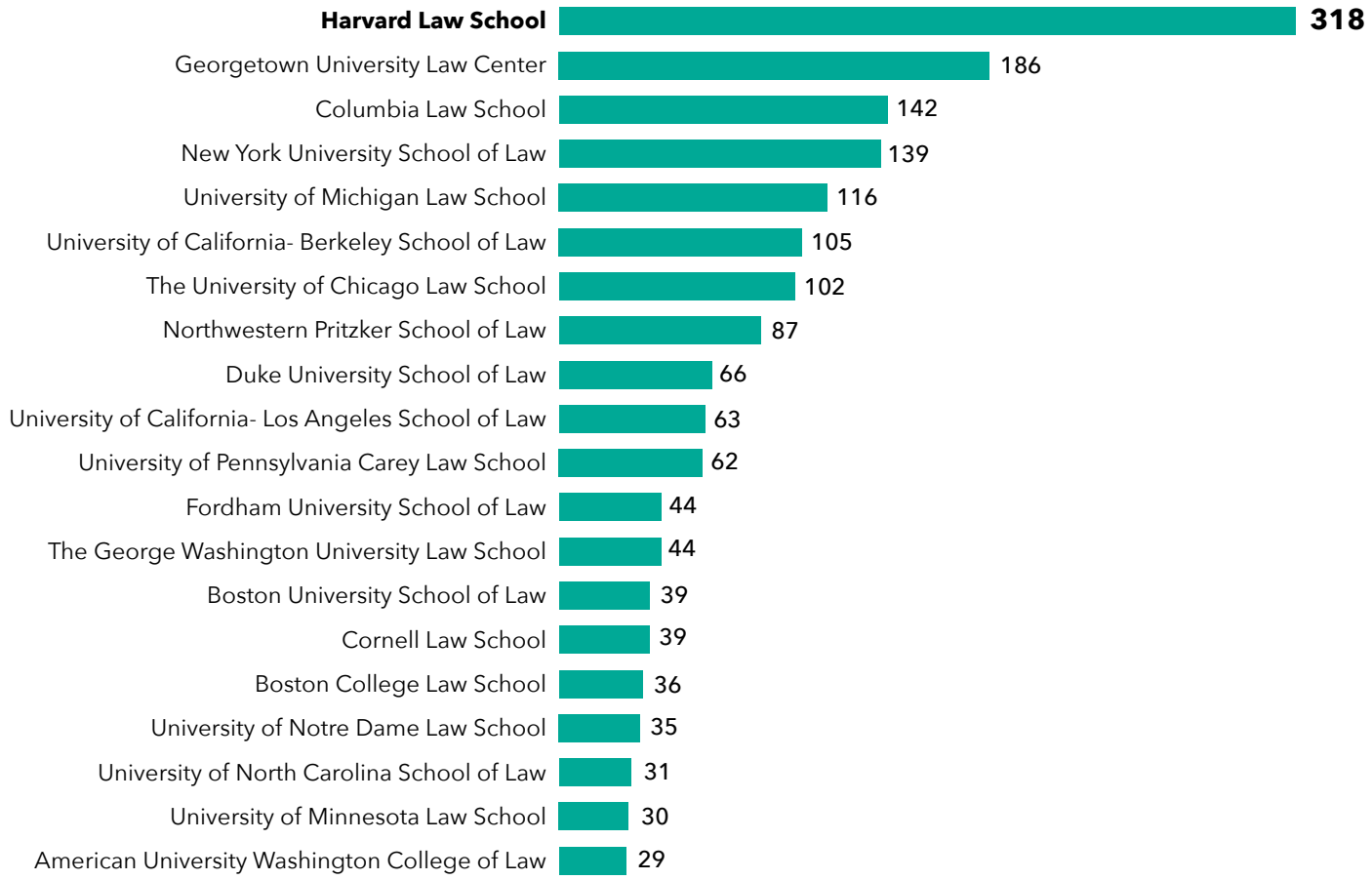
Students, faculty, and attorneys alike who didn't learn the law at Harvard would have liked to have attended the oldest law school in the country.

More than 300 people cited Harvard as one of their top three choices for a different law school other than their own.

That number far outpaced **Georgetown**, the second most popular choice. **Columbia**, **New York University**, and the **University of Michigan** round out the top five alternate law school choices.

If you didn't go to your law school, **where else would you have liked to go**? *Select up to three.*

Top 20 Responses



Prestige Metrics

Peer Perceptions: Areas of Expertise

Which law schools produce the best attorneys in each of the following categories?
Select up to three.

Litigators

Harvard Law School	**98**
Baylor University School of Law	32
The University of Chicago Law School	31
New York University School of Law	24
Georgetown University Law Center	19
University of Michigan Law School	18
Columbia Law School	16

Legal Writers

Harvard Law School	**131**
The University of Chicago Law School	48
Stanford Law School	23
Yale Law School	20
Columbia Law School	19
Georgetown University Law Center	16
University of Michigan Law School	16

Transactional Attorneys

Harvard Law School	**100**
Columbia Law School	56
New York University School of Law	46
The University of Chicago Law School	28
Stanford Law School	21
The University of Texas School of Law	19
University of Virginia School of Law	19

In-House Corporate Attorneys

Harvard Law School	**76**
Columbia Law School	42
New York University School of Law	32
Stanford Law School	30
The University of Chicago Law School	29
Yale Law School	28
University of Michigan Law School	26

Harvard is considered tops in producing litigators, legal writers, transactional attorneys and in-house counsel. Columbia and New York University were voted second and third, respectively, for producing the best transactional and in-house lawyers.

Harvard Law School dominates almost every category, but other schools stand out as well. **Lawyers with Stanford degrees are perceived as the most tech savvy**, with the law school near Silicon Valley scoring 116 votes from respondents. **UC Berkeley Law** is a distant second.

The **University of Chicago** was cited second-most for producing legal writers but was edged out by **Baylor University** when it comes to developing litigators.

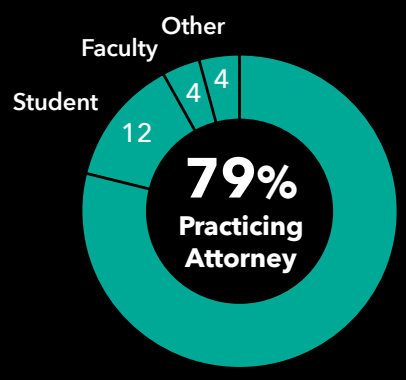
Technologically Savvy Attorneys

Stanford Law School	**116**
University of California-Berkeley School of Law	44
Harvard Law School	28
New York University School of Law	21
Georgetown University Law Center	15
Chicago-Kent College of Law	13
Yale Law School	12

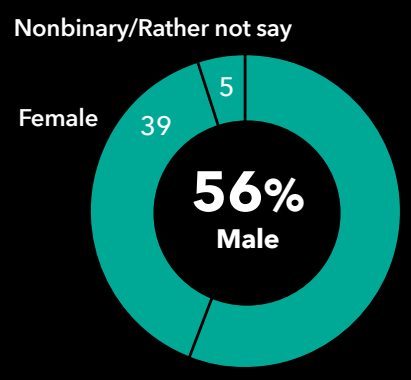
Respondent Demographics

All Respondents

Occupation

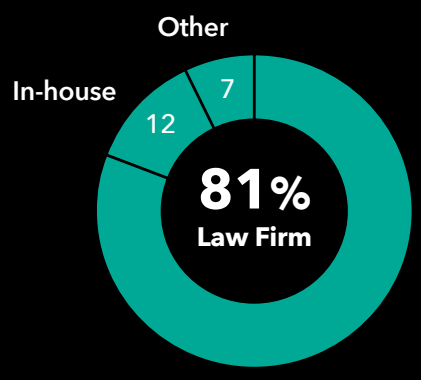


Gender



Attorneys

Workplace

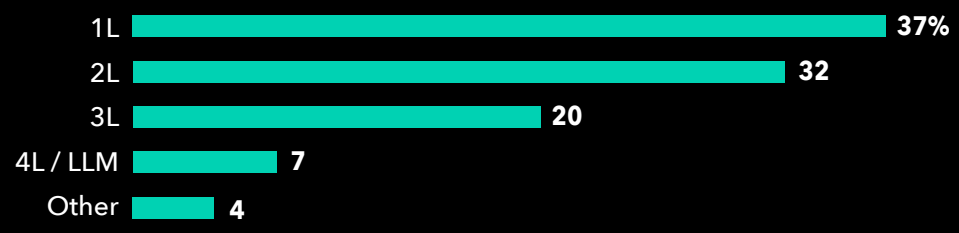


Professional Title

Partner	39%
Associate	25
Other Attorney (general)	20
Counsel	11
In-House Counsel	5

Students

Year



METHODOLOGY: This annual survey was drafted with help from subject-matter analysts and journalists at Bloomberg Law. Responses were received from 1,558 practicing attorneys, 79 law school faculty, and 264 law students from Oct. 28-Nov. 17, 2025. Among the practitioners who responded, 95% were practicing lawyers and 5% were paralegals, librarians, or in legal operations. Data are reported and aggregated by category with no personal information retained, except for report distribution upon request. Respondents answered questions based on their occupation and provided some demographic information. Responses such as "don't know" or "prefer not to say" are not reflected in graphics.

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